are matters that require coordination on day-to-day issues, coordinated patrols on the border by the Army or CORPATs of the Navy, for example. If the two armies or navies do not coordinate, it is the smugglers and other anti-national elements who will have a field day. I am also asked, in most aggrieved tones, as to why Myanmar is siding with China. Well, they are doing it out of compulsion. When nobody else is helping them out and China is offering a carte blanche, what else do you expect? Our foreign policy cannot be based on trying to cling to a moral high horse but on ground realities and national interest. While we shut our doors to Myanmar, China threw theirs wide open. The effect is starkly visible. More than half of the business establishments in Mandalay, the second-largest town after Yangon, are Chinese-owned. The Chinese have their own gated communities, out of bounds for local Myanmar citizens. Going towards the border with China, the situation is even worse, with 75 to 80 per cent of the businesses being Chinese-owned, and the yuan is the currency of choice. All this did not happen overnight but in the two decades or so when the West turned a blind eye, while at the same time supporting military dictatorships in other parts of the world, including Pakistan.

Almost immediately after our arrival was the Monks' Revolution, or the Saffron Revolution as it was dubbed by the Western media with their penchant for giving colour to various revolutions (pun intended). It all started when a group of monks were manhandled by some Army personnel in Mandalay, the temporal seat of Buddhism in Myanmar, in August 2007. This was not taken well and the Buddhist monks started protests, initially in Mandalay itself, and progressing to other population centres, including Yangon. At about the same time, the government removed all fuel subsidies, linking fuel prices to the international market, which caused fuel prices to

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